

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

Learn about the print production cycle in this month's feature. Then, head over to Geek-key to learn about famous gunsmiths and the guns they're famous for. Then in DGT, check out some cool gadgets and find out what we've been watching.



Trekking for a signal

It is not just your grandparents who trekked up to mountain tops just to go to school, kids in the Philippines are doing it even today, and this uplifting gallery of kids studying seriously in all kinds of environments may just be the dose of glee surfing that you need. <http://dgit.in/mntrek>

WHAT'S NEW

Tech invasion of 2021

Over the course of 2020, the regular workhorse software got a big boost such as cloud based office suites, or video calling apps, digital payment systems, or collaborative messaging platforms. Another example is that of augmented reality, where many more people got introduced to the wonders of adding filters and backgrounds onto their webcam streams. Going forward into 2021, we can expect an increase in digitisation, and a revitalisation of some kinds of software that haven't seen the expected widespread adoption. A good example of such technology is that of chatbots. People will decide between an online shopping experience or a virtual one going forward. Interacting with a



salesman who can give valuable advice on a purchase such as a laptop may provide more value to the buyer than a pureline

online experience. It is here that chatbots can have a major role to play, retaining more shoppers in cyberspace. We can also expect an uptick in all the technologies aimed at making people keep their hands to themselves; reducing touchpoints or interactions. For example, we may see technologies that allow smartphones to make contactless payments at greater distances.

<http://dgit.in/t2020>

The science of getting chills when you listen to music

For some people, listening to music can be an eerie, thrilling experience, even giving goosebumps to some people and what are described as "chills". The French have a term for it, known as "frisson". However, this is a feeling that not everyone gets, only two thirds of humans experience frisson, and researchers suspect that evolution has something to do with it. After over five decades of research,



researchers have found indications that it has to do with how humans emotionally react to novel stimuli in their surroundings, such as music. Unexpected hormones, sudden changes in volume, or

a moving solo are all considered triggers for frisson, which occurs when expectations of the listener is broken in a positive way. Common examples of these events are in talent shows where a participant who might not appear confident or professional stuns the audience once they start performing, such as Susan Boyle's 2009 debut on Britain's got Talent.

<http://dgit.in/muschillx>



Slender man and creepypasta

A professor in American folklore explores how folklore interacts with media such as video games, supernatural movies, and creepypastas on the internet. Creepypastas such as slenderman can spread easily because they deliberately confuse the issue of their own reality.

<http://dgit.in/crpydl>



The game plays you

A game designers analysis of QAnon, an extreme right wing conspiracy theory shows that the conspiracy is growing because of misinterpretation of random data, presented in suggestive manners, similar to random textures in a game pointing to a hidden clue, when there is none.

<http://dgit.in/qanon>



Zero employees

Gumroad is a creator platform that has no meetings, no full time employees, and no offices. Instead of focusing on profits at all costs, the founder focused on employee freedom at all cost, because that is what they themselves wanted. The result is a surprisingly viable business.

<http://dgit.in/slwork>